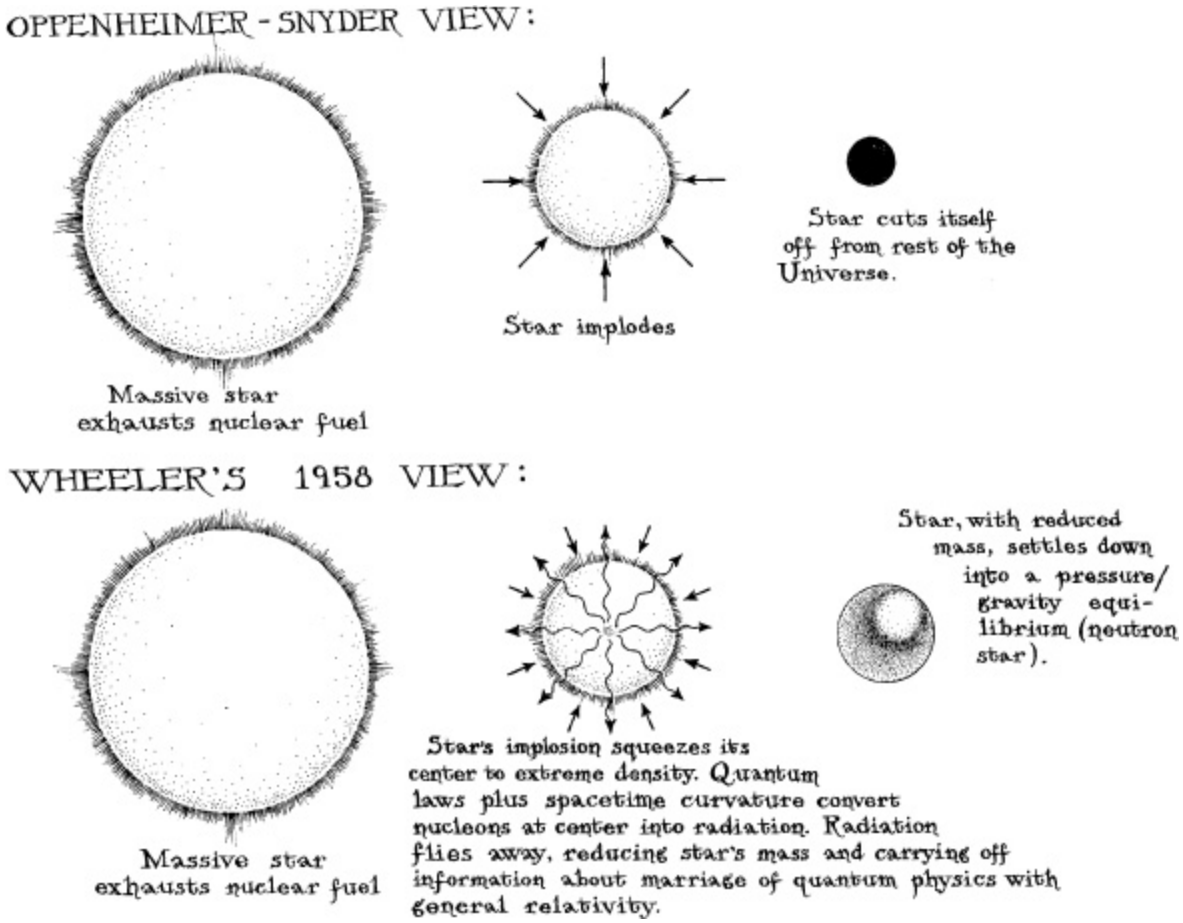
undergo continued gravitational contraction and ultimately cut themselves off more and more from the rest of the Universe [that is, form black holes]?" (See Figure 6.1.)



6.1 Contrast of Oppenheimer's view of the fates of large masses (*upper sequence*) with Wheeler's 1958 view (*lower sequence*).

Wheeler was equally polite, but held his ground. "It is very difficult to believe 'gravitational cutoff is a satisfactory answer," he asserted.

Oppenheimer's confidence in black holes grew out of detailed calculations he had done nineteen years earlier:

Black-Hole Birth: A First Glimpse

In the winter of 1938–39, having just completed his computation with George Volkoff of the masses and circumferences of neutron stars (Chapter 5), Oppenheimer was firmly convinced that massive stars, when they die,